STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 09 · Anger, the Itch, and the Drift

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Good to see you in the room. Uh, I got here a little early. Straightened a stack of books that was already straight. Then I left them alone. They were fine. Yeah. I know that move. Give me a small job so I don't have to walk into a real one. Some of you, uh, did a cousin of that out in your truck. Uh, hands on the wheel. Coming through the door is the harder job. Glad you took it. Uh, last time we named the chair. What sat there was handed to you. What you do with it is yours. I'm not— I'm not gonna walk that road again. Today is the fruit. What comes out of a man when the ache gets heavy and he will not carry it. Pain does not sit still in you. It moves. It finds a way out. I have a way. You have a way. Uh, most of us named it after ourselves. Called it personality. You know, that sounds cleaner. Temperament. Just how I'm built. It isn't how you're built. It's how— it's how you learned not to feel a thing. The ache leaves three ways. Out, and it looks like anger. Down, and it looks like appetite. Away, and the man is simply gone. Anger. The itch. The drift. You don't need all three on your record. One of them answers before you've held a meeting. That one is yours. If the chair talk is still settling in you, you're not late to this. Every man in here has an ache and a way he spends it. A lot of men will swear they don't. They get quiet. They get— they get reasonable. They get, uh, very productive. You know, same door. If a hard stretch sends you through more than one, you probably blocked the favorite. The ache went looking. Name the one you live in. Today we name the way.

One sentence puts four marks down for what a real man is. I have not found a cleaner list. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Uh, you've heard them in this room. I'm not gonna tour the whole list. Today they stand over the fruit. Not over the old seat. Uh, passivity has a quiet costume and a loud one. The drift is passivity with your body still in the house. The itch is passivity that would rather not be known. Anger can look like the opposite. A man running the room. Sometimes it's a refusal to say what's under the heat. Uh, responsibility is that sentence. The exit, and the thing beneath it. Uh, courage is the next move while it still costs you. I mean, the exits all pay fast. Anger pays a rush that feels like power. The itch pays relief. The drift pays a cheap peace. None of those hold in the morning. God's pay is a man who stayed and told the truth. I watched a man get praised for being even while his people lived on scraps of him. Even is not the same as present. Uh, a calm face can still be an exit. Passivity will wear a compliment if you let it. Here's the claim. Your main exit is not your personality. It is— it is an old way of not feeling something, and it still answers to your name. Uh, shame will try to run the hour. Don't let it do the teaching. Uh, shame makes every exit stronger. I will not shame you. I will not pat the fruit and pretend it is only a wound. The old hurt may explain the door. You still decide whether you walk through it today.

Anger is the exit a lot of men trust. It looks like strength. Get under it, though. Uh, most days you'll find fear there. Or shame. Or a helplessness you cannot stand. You got talked over, and you smiled. Uh, your boy is struggling, and you have no lever. You said a thing yesterday you can't unsay, and it's still in the room. Uh, every one of those feels like weakness. Anger feels like power. So a man— so a man grabs it the way he grabs the loudest thing in reach. Uh, the moment in front of him didn't build the heat. It just walked in while he was already hot. You've felt that, right? Uh, the size of it doesn't match the spark. How many of you get a sharp sentence in your mouth before you've named the real thing? Hands. Nobody's collecting them. Yeah. That's a lot of loaded sentences walking around in here. The heat picks a target fast. A tone in your voice. A driver who moved over. A backpack in the doorway. Uh, the target is almost never the thing that actually hurt. You can feel it in the jaw first. Then the hands. Then a sentence you'll wish you could catch. Uh, let me tell on myself. I have fixed things that were not the problem. A hinge that squeaked a little. I stood there with a screwdriver while a real conversation waited on the other side of the door. That hinge has never been quieter. The conversation is still waiting. That's not a fix. That's an exit with a tool in its hand. Uh, I looked useful. I was leaving. If you remember one line from this part, remember this. The loud thing is often a cover for a man who feels small.

I came through my own door already tight. Bad day. I was not gonna talk about it. Uh, there were shoes in the hall. Not a crisis. I picked them up like they'd insulted the house. My voice got particular. Uh, a kid of mine watched the shoes, not my face. He was learning what to do with his shoulders when I come in hot. Uh, I caught it. Not fast. I went out to the back step and stood there until my hands changed. Then I came in and said it. It's not the shoes. I'm wound up, and I brought it home. Something in the day had made me feel small. The shoes were a thing I could win. Uh, listen to the verse on this. Ephesians four, verses twenty-six and twenty-seven. In your anger do not sin. Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry, and do not give the devil a foothold. The verse doesn't ban the anger. It meets you in it. Then it sets a clock. Sundown. Then it names the danger. A place for the enemy to stand. He doesn't need a scene. He needs you to lie down still holding it, and pick it up again in the morning. Leave it there. The house starts to plan around you. People get careful when you come in. Uh, that's a foothold learning the rooms. So here's the move. When the heat hits, don't spend the sentence you've got loaded. Step out. Back step. End of the hall. The far side of the driveway. Uh, stop feeding it with your mouth. The surge will crest, and if you let it, it starts to drop. Then you walk— you walk back in and you say the thing under it. I'm scared. I'm ashamed. I felt small, and I spent it on you. Settle it before the sun is down. Don't take it to sleep with you.

The second exit goes down. Appetite. Uh, sex has the strongest grip, so I won't pretend it's a side note. The same itch runs other places, though. Uh, a drink you keep where nobody checks. A box on the porch you didn't need, slid into the garage before anyone sees it. A game you keep refreshing because the next play might settle your chest. A screen that will sit with you as long

as you want and never once ask your name. Comfort now. No cost you have to say out loud. No witness. Uh, you didn't put it on a calendar. It just— it just took the night, or the drive, or whatever scrap of the day was left. And you were not hunting joy, not mostly. You were hunting relief. Uh, relief from the day. Relief from a room where somebody might need the real you. That's the pull. The lie sits right beside it. Being needed, and being known, is the road that actually helps a man. Block this door and don't be shocked if the ache tries another. You shut the appetite and the temper shows up. Or you go quiet. Uh, that is one ache hunting a way not to be felt. The day a brother can describe the habit, it has to shrink or get honest. A hidden stretch will not build you. I mean, it asks nothing, and that's why it feels like mercy. It isn't mercy. Uh, watch what goes first. Your attention thins out around the people who love you. Then your want for a real person thins out. Then you get clever at looking past them. She can feel the gap before she can name it. If there's no wife, a brother can feel it too. You start answering from far away. The life is still on the schedule. You are harder to find.

There's a line for this in Second Timothy, chapter two, verse twenty-two. Flee the evil desires of youth, and pursue righteousness, faith, love, and peace, along with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart. Flee. Not manage. Not a tidier plan. Run. And the verse does not send you out alone. Along with those who call on the Lord. That's a man in it with you. So if this is your exit, here is the work. Tell one man what you actually do. Uh, how often it has you. How long it's been the door. What it's costing. Uh, don't hand him a soft label he can't picture. Hand him the real thing. Then put the way back in his hands. The password. If he holds the way in, you have to face a man to get to it. Uh, set the kind of rule you'd set for your own son without an argument. The screen doesn't sleep next to you. It lives out where a life is happening. I have— I have sat in my own driveway with the engine off. House lit. Somebody moving around in there. Me in the dark with a phone, calling it a minute to come down. I knew the score of a game I don't even follow. The house was right there. The phone was easier. Uh, when I was younger and a day went wrong, I bought food I didn't want. Ate it in the truck. Music up. Then walked in ready to play normal. Uh, the sack was not dinner. It was a few quiet minutes where nobody needed a man out of me. Same door as the darker stuff. Comfort now. No witness. No cost I had to say. So find the man. Uh, tell him the real habit before you talk yourself down. The itch shrinks in a man who is known. It does not shrink in a man with a better hiding spot.

The third exit is the quiet one. Uh, I worry about it because the house still looks alright. Nobody calls it a crisis. You leave without taking a step. Your body stays. You answer from somewhere else. The people who love you learn to stop bringing you the real thing, because the answers got small. Uh, a kid learns that a father can be home and still be hard to find. Under it, almost every time, there is a hurt. Uh, somewhere you made a rule you never said out loud. I will not want a thing that can be taken from me. Or you were— or you were honestly empty, and a rest turned, inch by inch, into a way of being gone. Uh, I have lived the small version. Sat at my own table. Nodded through a whole story. Caught the last sentence. Answered the last sentence.

The middle had already been said. I asked a question the middle had already finished. She didn't need a sharper reply. She needed a man who was in the story while she was telling it. Scripture puts a finger on this without raising its voice. Deuteronomy six. Talk about them when you sit at home. Sitting under the same roof is not the same as being home. You can share a kitchen and never sit down inside the conversation. If this is your exit, say it. To your wife, if you have one. To a brother, if you don't. You had my body. You did not have me. I'm sorry. Then give the room an evening back. Screens dark. One real question. You wait until the answer is finished, not until you've got your line ready. A house can thin out one quiet question at a time. Uh, nobody writes that up. That is a man coming back into his own house.

I'll tell you about a man I know. Uh, I'll call him Lonnie. Steady. The kind of dad other men point at when they want to say calm. He stood the fence at his boy's games with his arms loose, like he had all day. Uh, one game, between innings, he said he was getting a water. He didn't make it back. I, uh, found him down the line, working a splinter in the rail with his thumb, eyes on the dirt. I told him he was missing it. He said— he said he could hear it from there. He couldn't. His boy made a play and looked down the fence for his dad. The spot was empty. Uh, after the game we sat on the tailgate. I said, he looked for you. Lonnie got quiet in a way I recognized. Uh, a while back he had helped with a team of boys. One of them took a bad fall. Lonnie had told him to shake it off before he knew what he was looking at. The boy was hurt worse than that. Lonnie decided, and he never announced it, that leaning in close was how you got somebody broken. So he practiced being a step outside his life and called it steady. You know, the other dads liked him for it. His boy inherited the distance. I didn't have a speech on that tailgate. I asked what his boy had been trying to hand him. Lonnie went and found him. Asked him to tell the play again. The boy said, you were there. Lonnie said, I was down the fence. Tell me anyway. And he waited until the boy was done talking. Nobody threw a thing. The day looked ordinary from the bleachers. A boy told a story to a spot on the fence where a man should have been. That's the drift. The refusal was a second ask, and staying for the whole answer.

Lonnie didn't look like a man in trouble. Uh, that is why the drift fools a room. Let me put another man next to him. Different door. Uh, I'll call him Gus. We were after a bracket in a hardware aisle. Small thing. The clerk couldn't find it. Gus's voice got big. People turned. The clerk's face went red. Uh, outside, Gus's hands were shaking. He said he didn't know why a bracket did that. I asked what the morning had already taken. His brother had called, asking for money again. Gus had felt like a fool for hoping. The clerk was just the first person Gus could beat. Under the volume was shame. The bracket never had a chance. Same ache. Lonnie stepped off the fence. Gus filled an aisle. Two exits. One move underneath. Get away from the feeling. Uh, you can trace it. The angry man learned that fear made him look weak, so he picked a feeling that passed for power. The man with the itch learned he could get comfort that never asked his name. The drifting man learned that caring had a price, and he stopped paying it

where anybody could see. That explains— that explains the exit. It does not excuse the fruit. I mean, you can tell the old story and keep the foothold. If all you bring is the wound, you will get sympathy, and you will keep the door. Kind is not a pass. Present sin still counts. Both men had a softer name for it. Uh, the softer name is how an exit stays. Block the exit you favor and watch. The ache will try the next door. That is not proof you are a special kind of broken. It is proof the ache moves. Don't tour all three so you never have to refuse one.

The exit changes clothes depending on the life you're in. It does not close. Uh, young men. The itch will call itself normal. The early drift will call itself you being your own man. Headphones through a whole evening. A day you sleepwalk and still get paid. Numb, at your age, is not peace. It's a man already leaving. Uh, if you're single, hear this clean. A wife— a wife will not starve this. Don't put the fight on layaway until there's a ring. Marriage is good. It is not a cure you get to wait on. You already have a life. Tell a brother now. Uh, husbands. She already knows the exit. You don't owe her a speech about your childhood as the whole offering. You can tell the old story. You may not use it as rent while the door stays open. She can work with a true sentence. She cannot build a life with a man who keeps leaving in place. New dads. The heat will catch you when you are empty and the house is loud. Then say it. I'm emptied out. Uh, I'm scared of my own tone. She can stand with that. She can't stand with a man who treats the noise as an attack. Dads of daughters. She is learning what a man's anger does in a room, and what his absence does. Don't make her guess which one she gets today. Uh, if you were hurt, I am not rushing you. What was done to you is real. The fruit on the tree now is still yours. If the marriage ended, all three doors can swing in the same stretch of days. Anger with her name still on it. Appetite, because the place got quiet. Absence, because caring is what got you cut. Get one man who will ask again. Don't hand him a speech and call the work done. The exit is still his. The refusal is still his.

Older men, stay with me. You may have, uh, stopped yelling. Watch the leftover heat. A cold silence is still an exit people have to live beside. And watch the drift. Uh, mellow is not the same word as refused. A calm man can be gone a long time and get credit for peace. Uh, if the work is going well, don't relax. Competence is not repentance. Ambition can be a foothold. Ease can be one too. You can win the day and spend the ache after dark. The people in your house do not experience your resume. They experience whether you came back in. If the kids are grown and the house has gone quiet, the drift will call that your reward. It isn't. She is still there. Uh, ask her something real. Then wait it out. Bring her the man, not the leftovers of him. How many of you already know your exit, and you've been calling it personality? Let me see them. Yeah. I figured. That knowing is not the refusal. It's the start of one. So pick the home door. Not a tour. If you name all three, you can leave here feeling honest and still feed every one of them. One exit. Write it like a man who means to stop. Uh, on the drive after this, if the heat comes up in the truck, you already know the move. You don't spend the sharp sentence on the steering wheel, or on the first person you see. You hold it. You say the true thing to the person it belongs

to. If the pull is the itch, you don't negotiate with it in the cab. You tell the man who is allowed to know. If the pull is to go vague, you come back into the room before the evening is gone. One door. One refusal. That's the work.

Let me land the whole thing. Pain moves. Out, as anger. Down, as the itch. Away, as the drift. Uh, a man calls his favorite one personality. It is an old way of not feeling something, and it leads out of the house. What I hope— what I hope you carry is not a cleaner opinion of yourself. I hope you walk out with one exit named, and one refusal you will actually do. Uh, your workbook is the place it gets particular. In a minute you'll get with your table and work this part together. Uh, so hear the questions. When things get heavy, I blank. Finish it out loud. Anger, the itch, or the drift. One full sentence. Not a list. What is under the last time you took that exit? Not the version that makes you the hero. The thing you were trying not to feel. And what is the first move that matches it? If it's anger, get out of the room until the heat starts down, then say what is under it, before the sun is down. If it's the itch, tell one man the whole truth and let him hold the password. If it's the drift, give the room an evening, screens dark, and one real question you wait for. Tell him your exit and the last time you took it. Ask him his. Uh, neither of you gets to say you're fine. Carry this when you stand up. Out, down, or away, every exit leads out of the house. The pain does not need an exit. It needs a Father. The marks still stand over it. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Own the fruit. Tables are yours. Do this part of the workbook together. I'll be close by.